

WESTERN BANGLA EDUCATION (WBE)

White Paper

Student Mobility in South Asia (2020–2025): Opportunity, Disruption, and Decision-Making

An Evidence-Based Analysis

Source Statement: This paper synthesizes data from official international sources including UNESCO UIS, national statistical bureaus, immigration authorities, and parliamentary records. Where data is incomplete, ranged, or conflicting, these limitations are reported transparently and are not harmonized.

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Abstract: This white paper examines student mobility patterns in South Asia from 2020 to 2025, analyzing outbound flows from Bangladesh, India, and Pakistan alongside bilateral corridors. Opportunity structures—including cost, educational access, degree recognition, and scholarship availability—provide more consistent explanations for student movement than geopolitical alignment alone. This analysis is based on UNESCO UIS data, national survey statistics (AISHE, BANBEIS), immigration records, and official government reports.

Keywords: student mobility, South Asia, Bangladesh, India, Pakistan, higher education, international students, geopolitics, UNESCO, cross-border education, medical education, study abroad, education policy

1 Executive Summary

The available evidence indicates that student mobility in South Asia cannot be explained by diplomatic alignment alone. Bangladesh’s outbound series is the clearest in the dataset, rising from 49,150 in 2020 to 52,799 in 2023 after a temporary dip in 2021. Pakistan’s 2023 outward total of 71,865 serves as a UNESCO-comparable annual outbound tertiary count. Together, these figures demonstrate that outward demand remains substantial even in a politically volatile regional environment.

Key Insight: Even during periods of regional instability and diplomatic friction, the aggregate volume of student movement from South Asia remained structurally intact.

India operates at a much larger outbound scale than Bangladesh or Pakistan, but the evidence is divided between UNESCO-style mobility counts and broader Ministry of External Affairs / Bureau of Immigration counts. This division prevents a single harmonized annual series for India in this paper. India can therefore be treated as a major outbound system, but without precise boundaries.

Bilateral corridors reinforce the same conclusion. India→Bangladesh and India→China are best understood as active student stock rather than annual flow, while Pakistan→China is supported mainly through scholarship evidence. Bangladesh-in-India is captured through AISHE enrollment stock rather than UNESCO-style outward flow. Even where measurement systems differ, the evidence continues to point toward opportunity structures as the most durable explanation of movement.

2 Introduction

Student mobility in South Asia is frequently attributed to geopolitics. The evidence examined in this paper suggests this explanation is incomplete. Students continue to move, return, delay, or redirect themselves through systems shaped by cost, access, recognition, and degree utility. Demand does not simply disappear under pressure; it reorganizes under constraint.

This matters because South Asian mobility is being shaped by multiple simultaneous shocks. Pandemic border closures, policy tightening, political unrest, and bilateral hostility all affected student movement between 2020 and 2025. Simultaneously, students continued to pursue med-

ical education, English-medium study, scholarships, and externally recognized qualifications. Crisis altered routes and timing more directly than it erased aspiration.

This paper does not argue that geopolitics is irrelevant. It makes a narrower claim: in the current evidence base, geopolitical shocks interrupt mobility, but they do not explain destination choice as consistently as opportunity factors do. That conclusion rests on disciplined comparison rather than rhetorical force.

Key Insight: Geopolitical shocks interrupt mobility but do not erase demand; students redirect rather than abandon their educational objectives.

3 Method and Data Limits

The available evidence combines annual outbound totals, active enrollment stock, institution-based foreign student counts, and scholarship counts. These measures are not interchangeable. Bangladesh’s UNESCO-based outbound series is the cleanest directly comparable sequence available, while several India and corridor figures come from different systems altogether. In this paper, methodological caution is part of the argument rather than an external limitation.

Key Insight: Stock and flow data measure different populations; conflating them produces misleading conclusions about corridor size and direction.

For India, the compiled data includes both UNESCO-style internationally mobile student counts and broader Ministry of External Affairs / Bureau of Immigration counts of Indian nationals travelling abroad for study or education. The conflict in available totals is therefore partly a metric conflict, not just a disagreement between sources. Different state and international systems are counting overlapping but non-identical populations, so India can be discussed in scale terms, but not as a single settled annual line.

For India inbound and Bangladesh-in-India figures, the current evidence comes from AISHE institutional enrollment reporting. These are better treated as active stock in Indian institutions rather than annual outbound flow from the country of origin. The same caution applies to India→Bangladesh and India→China, where the strongest figures currently reflect active student stock rather than annual movement. Stock and flow therefore remain separate throughout the paper.

For Pakistan, the available 2023 outbound figure is stronger than the Pakistan→China corridor evidence. The compiled data identifies the 71,865 total as a UNESCO-comparable outbound tertiary count, while Pakistan→China remains represented mainly through scholarship evidence rather than a clean annual movement series. Pakistan can therefore enter regional comparison more confidently at the national level than at the corridor level.

4 How Students Actually Decide

The available evidence repeatedly demonstrates practical decision criteria rather than abstract diplomatic affinity. These include affordability, access to medical education, curriculum fit, English-medium study options, and scholarships. Students appear to choose destinations that

solve concrete educational problems, which makes mobility look less like symbolic alignment and more like constrained optimization.

Affordability matters because many of the visible corridors in the evidence are not prestige-first pathways. India→Bangladesh and India→China both become legible through cost-sensitive medical education logic rather than elite institutional signaling. Lower-cost or functionally accessible destinations remain attractive even where risk increases, demonstrating that price and educational access can outweigh political discomfort.

Recognition and curriculum fit matter because students do not simply move to where admission is possible. They move where the degree remains usable for later licensing, employment, or social mobility. Even where the paper lacks a fully standardized measure for every destination, the evidence repeatedly returns to degree utility. Students are therefore not only buying admission; they are investing in a viable educational trajectory.

Mobility also responds to the structure of choice rather than to a single destination image. When one route becomes more expensive, more tightly regulated, or harder to access, students do not necessarily abandon outward mobility. They look for substitutes that preserve enough of the same value. In this dataset, decision-making is adaptive rather than binary.

Key Insight: Students optimize for practical value under constraint; destination choice reflects adaptive search rather than fixed preference.

5 South Asia Mobility Overview

Bangladesh has the clearest recent outbound sequence in the available evidence base. The UNESCO-based totals move from 49,150 in 2020 to 44,338 in 2021, then recover to 49,151 in 2022 and 52,799 in 2023. The one-year decline is followed by recovery above the 2020 level, demonstrating that outward demand was disrupted but not structurally weakened.

Table 1: Bangladesh Outbound Tertiary Students 2020–2023

Year	2020	2021	2022	2023
Outbound Students	49,150	44,338	49,151	52,799
Year-on-Year Change	—	−9.8%	+10.9%	+7.4%

Source: UNESCO Institute for Statistics (UIS), cross-referenced with BANBEIS.

India operates at a much larger outbound scale, but the available sources do not support a fully harmonized annual series. Some figures are UNESCO-comparable, while others come from broader MEA and Bureau of Immigration tracking of Indian nationals travelling abroad for study or education. India’s outward weight is real, but its precise annual magnitude depends on which counting system is used.

Pakistan remains incomplete as a multi-year series, but the available 2023 figure is stronger than earlier data. The compiled data identifies the 71,865 total as a UNESCO-comparable outbound tertiary count, which allows Pakistan to enter cross-country discussion for that year.

Taken together, these country cases suggest that the region cannot be described through a single mobility model. Bangladesh offers the cleanest comparable outward trend, India shows

Table 2: India Outbound: Measurement System Comparison

Year	UNESCO-Style Count	MEA/Bureau Count	Metric Type
2020	516,693	685,097	Annual outbound
2021	508,174	1,158,702	Annual outbound
2022	—	907,404	Annual outbound
2023	508,174	1,318,955	Annual outbound
2024	—	1,335,878	Annual outbound
2021–2022	46,878 (inbound)	—	Active enrollment stock

Source: UNESCO UIS (UNESCO-style); Ministry of External Affairs / Bureau of Immigration (MEA counts). These systems are not interchangeable.

Table 3: Pakistan Outbound Tertiary Students 2023

Metric	Value
UNESCO-Comparable Outbound Students	71,865
Year	2023
Data Source	UNESCO UIS

Source: UNESCO Institute for Statistics (UIS). Single-year point estimate; multi-year series not yet available.

scale with measurement complexity, and Pakistan shows narrower but still material outward movement. Regional analysis therefore requires layered comparison rather than uniform ranking.

Key Insight: South Asia’s three major outbound systems operate at different scales and measurement standards; cross-country comparison requires methodological transparency.

6 Bilateral Mobility Corridors

Table 4: South Asia Bilateral Student Mobility Corridors: Available Evidence

Corridor	Direction	Estimate	Evidence Type
Bangladesh → India	Stock	2,606	AISHE enrollment
India → Bangladesh	Stock	8,000–9,000	Media/inst. estimate (residual)
India → China	Stock	10,000–15,000 (2024–2025)	Recovery estimate
India → China	Stock	23,000 (2019)	Pre-pandemic baseline
Pakistan → China	Scholarship	8,163	Scholarship beneficiaries

Source: AISHE, compiled evidence, media reporting. All stock figures represent active enrollment, not annual outbound flow. Estimates labeled as such.

6.1 Bangladesh to India

The Bangladesh-in-India figure of 2,606 comes from AISHE and reflects students on roll in Indian institutions, not a UNESCO-style annual outbound flow from Bangladesh. India remains a real destination for Bangladeshi students, but the available measure is an enrollment stock inside India. This corridor can therefore be discussed as a meaningful presence in Indian higher education, not as a directly comparable share of Bangladesh’s UNESCO outbound total.

6.2 India to Bangladesh

Available evidence suggests that Indian student presence in Bangladesh is driven heavily by medical education and appears to have expanded over time. The available figures are broad estimates of active Indian students enrolled in Bangladeshi medical colleges rather than a validated annual outbound series. This points to persistence in a cost-sensitive medical corridor despite political risk, but only through stock evidence rather than annual flow evidence.

6.3 India to China

The India→China figures available are active student stock estimates rather than annual outbound flows. The evidence indicates around 23,000 Indian students in China before the pandemic and only a low- to mid-teens-thousands recovery by 2024–2025. This reflects severe disruption followed by incomplete recovery. The corridor remained viable after the shock, though the current evidence does not justify a stable annual movement series.

6.4 Pakistan to China

The available evidence for Pakistan→China is still incomplete as a mobility count series. The strongest figures refer to Chinese Government Scholarship beneficiaries rather than a full annual outbound or enrollment total. This demonstrates visible institutional support without a clean movement series, so the corridor can indicate strong state-backed educational linkage but not yet a count comparable with other mobility measures.

Key Insight: Scholarship infrastructure creates corridor visibility, but scholarship counts and total mobility counts are not the same metric.

7 Bangladesh–India Deep Analysis

Table 5: Bangladeshi Students by Destination: Available Evidence

Destination	Estimated Students	Evidence Type
India	2,606	AISHE enrollment stock
UK	—	Fragmentary data
USA	—	Fragmentary data
Australia	—	Fragmentary data
Malaysia	—	Fragmentary data
Residual (total minus identified destinations)	~50,000	UNESCO total minus known destinations (residual)

Source: AISHE (India); UNESCO UIS (total). India share based on AISHE enrollment stock, not UNESCO-comparable outbound flow. Cells marked as fragmentary require additional sourcing.

The Bangladesh–India relationship matters because it sits at the intersection of regional proximity, educational accessibility, and data limitation. Bangladesh has a large and recoverable outbound series, while Bangladesh’s visible presence in India appears through AISHE institutional enrollment rather than UNESCO outward flow. The corridor is clearly active, but only partially visible through one measurement system.

Table 6: Bangladesh–India Corridor: Data Summary

Metric	Bangladesh → India	India → Bangladesh
Active Estimate	2,606	8,000–9,000 (est.)
Evidence Type	AISHE enrollment stock	Media/inst. estimate
Dominant Sector	General higher education	Medical education
Data Year	2021–2022	Recent estimate

Source: AISHE (Bangladesh → India); media and institutional reporting (India → Bangladesh). Not directly comparable metrics.

India is not absent from Bangladeshi student mobility; it is simply not captured in the same way as Bangladesh’s global outbound total. The figure of 2,606 indicates enrolled Bangladeshi students in Indian institutions, which is enough to establish corridor relevance but not enough to claim a directly comparable market share. Given Bangladesh’s total outbound volume, the scale of enrollment in India reflects underutilization rather than saturation. The regional option exists and functions, but at a level below its theoretical potential.

The corridor also matters analytically because it aligns with the paper’s broader opportunity logic. India is geographically close, regionally legible, and part of a larger educational environment in which English-medium study and cross-border familiarity matter. Even without a harmonized flow count, the corridor’s continued visibility inside Indian higher education demonstrates that students do use the regional option. Bangladesh–India therefore helps explain why opportunity can operate at regional scale, not only global scale.

Key Insight: Regional corridors function under geopolitical friction; proximity and accessibility create corridor resilience that diplomatic relations cannot fully explain.

At the same time, the available data does not yet provide a basis for treating India as the dominant destination for Bangladeshi students. Bangladesh’s broader outbound total is much larger than the AISHE stock visible in India, and the paper already notes the distinction between those metrics. Regional corridors matter, but they coexist with a much wider geography of outward aspiration. India can therefore be important without being central.

8 Global Disruption Context

The disruption record in the available evidence is substantial. China’s COVID border closures, Bangladesh’s 2024 unrest, and the India–Pakistan policy rupture all altered the conditions under which students could move, remain enrolled, or return. What emerges is interruption, delay, and redirection rather than a single uniform collapse. Geopolitical and policy shocks reshape mobility channels most clearly through friction.

India→China demonstrates this most visibly in the current evidence. The corridor moved from a pre-pandemic stock of roughly 23,000 to a much lower active presence by 2024–2025 after prolonged border restrictions and delayed return. This is not elimination, but incomplete restoration. Strong educational demand can survive a geopolitical shock even when the route does not recover fully.

India→Bangladesh provides a different kind of disruption case. The evidence links the corridor

to political unrest, evacuations, and elevated perceived risk, but it also preserves the fact of continuing student presence. Security shocks raise the cost of staying without automatically dissolving the educational rationale. Disruption often changes the price of mobility more than the existence of demand.

Pakistan's case shows the sharpest form of break when policy and security align against movement. Yet even here, the broader evidence suggests that student demand across South Asia tends to redirect when one route becomes harder. Some corridors collapse while regional or extra-regional search continues elsewhere, demonstrating that the system remains resilient in aggregate even when individual channels are not.

9 India's Position

India's position in the paper is strongest when treated as a practical regional actor rather than as a universally dominant destination. The current evidence does not yet provide sufficient basis for presenting India as the main solution to South Asian outward demand, and it does not yet provide sufficient basis for a clean globally comparable annual outbound series either. India's strength here lies in functional positioning, not in simplified ranking.

India matters because it appears in both directions of the mobility story. It is part of the region's large outward movement through its own outbound population, and it is also an institutional host through AISHE-recorded foreign student enrollment. This dual positioning gives it a structurally important place in the region even when its measurement systems remain uneven.

That position becomes clearer when the paper is equally clear about what India is not. It is not presented here as a universally preferred destination, and it is not presented as immune to the same pressures affecting other countries. India belongs in the strategic center of the discussion because of regional practicality, not because the evidence proves global primacy.

Key Insight: India's regional role is structurally important but analytically bounded; the evidence supports functional positioning, not simplified dominance claims.

10 Strategic Insight

Across the country totals and the corridor evidence, the most stable tendency is not geopolitical alignment but opportunity-seeking under constraint. Students continue to move toward systems that offer lower cost, access to medical training, scholarship support, or recognizable academic pathways. Practical value remains visible even in politically stressed corridors, which makes mobility look more like adaptive decision-making than diplomatic signaling.

This does not mean politics is secondary in every case. The disruption record clearly shows that border closure, visa rupture, and unrest can alter timing, scale, and direction. Geopolitics matters most here as a force of friction, while opportunity matters most as a force of attraction.

Key Insight: Disruption reshapes routes and timing more directly than it erases aspiration; the system recovers direction even when individual corridors do not.

The paper’s main argument therefore works best as a structured comparison rather than as a slogan. Bangladesh’s clean UNESCO series, Pakistan’s narrower but usable 2023 total, and the stock-based corridor evidence all point in the same direction when handled carefully. The evidence supports the view that opportunity is the stronger explanation, provided that unlike measures are not flattened into metric equivalence.

Key Insight: The strongest evidence for opportunity-based explanation comes from Bangladesh’s clean multi-year series, which shows disruption followed by recovery—a pattern inconsistent with pure alignment-based mobility.

11 Implications

For students, the available evidence suggests that destination choice is best understood as a trade-off among cost, access, recognition, and stability rather than a search for politically aligned countries. Routes remain attractive when they solve concrete educational problems, which suggests that student strategy is likely to remain pragmatic even when the political environment hardens.

For families, the same evidence implies that visible disruption should be interpreted alongside structural opportunity rather than instead of it. Border closures, unrest, and policy changes matter because they raise uncertainty, but they do not erase the reasons some destinations remain attractive. Risk and value are weighed together, which suggests that family decision-making in this space is likely to remain comparative rather than purely defensive.

For institutions and intermediaries, the paper suggests that corridor strength depends on clarity of access and clarity of outcome. Where the evidence shows sustained enrollment or repeated outward demand, the underlying attraction appears to be functional rather than symbolic. Educational systems gain resilience when they remain legible and usable under pressure, which suggests that regional competition for students is likely to be won through reliability and value rather than rhetoric.

Key Insight: Institutional resilience in cross-border education comes from maintaining access clarity and outcome reliability during disruption, not from political alignment.

12 Conclusion

The available evidence does not support a simplistic reading of South Asian student mobility as either geopolitics-driven or geopolitics-free. It demonstrates instead that movement is shaped by opportunity structures operating under political constraint. Students redirect, persist, or delay in response to shocks, but continue to search for viable educational pathways. Across the available evidence, opportunity provides the most consistent explanation of student mobility where movement remains possible.

That conclusion should remain appropriately bounded. Bangladesh provides the strongest clean outbound series, Pakistan provides a usable point of comparison for 2023, and India provides scale alongside metric inconsistency and corridor complexity. Together, these cases support analytical confidence without justifying overstatement.

Key Insight: Bounded claims reflect methodological discipline; the paper's analytical value lies in what the evidence can support, not in what it might wish to prove.

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